Lesson 18: Three Common Sentence Errors: Fragments, Run-ons and Comma Splices

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 8 Three Common Errors in Sentence Structure and Punctuation; Appendix C Punctuation.

In this lesson

You learn to find and fix the three most common sentence errors: fragments, run-ons and comma splices. You also learn to punctuate examples with "for example" and "such as", and the main rules of Appendix C. These errors are serious in formal writing, so check for them in every assignment.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify a fragment and fix it.
- Identify run-on and comma splice sentences and fix them in four different ways.
- Punctuate sentences with for example, for instance, such as, like and including.
- Use the main rules for commas, semicolons and colons, and edit a paragraph for all three errors.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
sentence fragment	an incomplete sentence: no subject, no verb, or a dependent clause alone	Because it brings new discoveries and innovations.
run-on sentence	two complete sentences with nothing to separate them	Science experts are called scientists they do important work.
comma splice	two complete sentences separated by just a comma	Children can also be scientists, this is good news.
independent / dependent clause	a "subject + verb" group that can stand alone / one that starts with when, because, if … and cannot stand alone	(dependent) When students start working, (independent) they apply …
semicolon (;)	"like a long comma or a short period"	Sports are common hobbies; baseball is especially popular.
citizen science	science projects in which ordinary people, often volunteers, collect and share data	Citizen scientists are a group of people like you and me.
citizen journalism	ordinary people publishing news stories and photos online	You have posted messages and photos on Facebook, so you are a citizen journalist.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
contribution (n)	give money, time, knowledge, etc. for a good purpose	I admire scientists for their contributions.
innovation (n)	new creation or discovery	It brings new discoveries and innovations.
recruit (v)	look for new members for a group, an organization, etc.	The project is still actively recruiting volunteers.
biased (adj)	with prejudice	It is possible that their news is biased.
mislead (v)	cause misunderstanding (past participle: misled)	Readers may be confused or misled.

Rules and explanations

1. Sentence fragments

A fragment is "a part, not a whole", like one piece of a puzzle. Short answers are fine in conversation ("Why not?" "Because it's hard for me."), but in formal writing fragments are serious mistakes. Common situations:

Situation	Fragment	Correction
missing subject, verb or both	Is an important class. / I afraid of science. / Too hard.	Science is an important class. / I am afraid of science. / Science is too hard.
a phrase cut off from its sentence	I admire scientists. For their contributions.	I admire scientists for their contributions.
a period between the dependent and the independent clause	When students start working. They apply the scientific knowledge to their work.	When students start working, they apply the scientific knowledge to their work.

To fix a fragment, add the missing subject or verb, or attach the fragment to the sentence before or after it. With a subordinating conjunction (when, if, because ...), remove the period; add a comma only if the dependent clause comes first: "Students apply the scientific knowledge to their work when they start working."

2. Run-ons and 3. comma splices

- A **run-on** is two complete sentences with nothing to separate them, like one car running on top of another: "You can change your posts you can also delete them."
- A **comma splice** is two complete sentences separated by just a comma, like two cars too close together in a "fender bender" (a small accident): "The project ended, there had been different issues." Students often make one when they try to fix a run-on. It is not a mistake in some other languages, so it is tricky.

Four ways to fix run-ons and comma splices

Way	Example
1. A period, and a capital letter for the next sentence	We have just learned about citizen science. Have you heard of citizen journalism?
2. A compound sentence: comma + FANBOYS, or semicolon + adverbial conjunction + comma	You can change your posts, or you can delete them. / You have posted messages and photos on Facebook; therefore, you are a citizen journalist.
3. A complex sentence with a subordinating conjunction (comma only if the dependent clause comes first)	The project ended because there had been different issues. / Because there had been different issues, the project ended.
4. One simple sentence	You can change or delete your posts.

Giving examples: for example, for instance, such as, like, including

These expressions often cause all three errors. Ask: does a word, a phrase or a complete sentence follow the expression?

Pattern	Example
complete sentence. For example, complete sentence.	There are many citizen journalism sites. For example, Global News Voices and Highway Ukraine Citizen Journalism Online are two of them.
complete sentence; for example, complete sentence.	There are many citizen journalism sites; for example, Global News Voices and ... are two of them.
complete sentence, for example, words or phrases.	There are many citizen journalism sites, for example, Global News Voices and ...
complete sentence (,) such as / like / including + words or phrases.	There are many citizen journalism sites(,) such as Global News Voices and ...

- "For instance" works exactly like "for example", with a comma after it. Capitalize "For" only after a period.
- "Such as", "like" and "including" are not followed by a complete sentence. The comma before them is optional; there is no comma after them.

Appendix C: main punctuation rules

- **Comma:** in a series of three or more items; after a transition, a prepositional phrase or a dependent clause at the beginning of a sentence; before FANBOYS in a compound sentence; after adverbial conjunctions; around a phrase that explains the noun before it ("Five pounds of mixed nuts, my second Christmas gift, will help him ..."); before a quote; in dates (December 31, 2017) and addresses.
- **Semicolon:** between two complete, closely related sentences, and before some adverbial conjunctions. No capital letter after it, unless the word is a proper name.
- **Colon:** before a list: "Two books are required for most reading courses: a textbook and a novel."

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - In Arabic writing, long sentences joined with commas and "and" are normal. In English, a comma alone between two complete sentences is a comma splice. Use a period, a semicolon or a conjunction.
> - Arabic has no capital letters. When you fix a run-on with a period, remember the capital letter at the start of the new sentence.

Practice

1. Exercise 1. These sentences are about citizen scientists. Write "True" for a complete sentence and "False" for a fragment.

1. Most people think that only experts can be scientists, but they are wrong.
2. Citizen scientists are a group of people like you and me.
3. Some people interested in science and willing to be part of a science project.
4. Observe the nature and record the data. For example, how often do squirrels run up and down trees in different seasons?
5. Other projects can involve measuring the rainfall and reporting the calculations.
6. Some projects are local, and some others are global.
7. Most of the citizen scientists are volunteers. From school age children to retirees.
8. Citizen scientists and professional scientists share ideas and data. When they work on the same project.
9. Citizen science covers many areas. In botany, ecology, medicine, engineering, and many others.
10. Because everyone collaborates with each other. Science advancement is a community effort.

2. Exercise 5. These sentences tell a real experience on social media. Each contains a comma splice or a run-on. Identify the type of error and correct it.

Example: People do not check facts some terrible mistakes may occur in the social media. → Run-on. When people do not check facts, some terrible mistakes may occur in the social media.

1. This is a true story, it happened a few years ago.
2. I was in a social media chat group with forty-five former classmates we had attended the same junior high school class many years before.
3. One day, one of the classmates posted a message, it said that Mr. Wu, one of our teachers, had just passed away.
4. We were very sad we shared our old memories of that teacher in the chat.
5. Two days later, a message popped up it was from Mr. Wu!
6. Some classmates had invited him to join the chat group a while back. He seldom spoke we forgot that he was in the group.
7. Mr. Wu protested nicely that he was still alive, he even posted his recent photo to prove that.

8. We were relieved we started to greet him.
9. The student who had posted the wrong news was embarrassed, we did not blame him.
10. This incident shows the importance of checking the facts we were pleased that the fact was a happy one in our case.

3. Exercise 7. Complete each sentence with specific examples. Pay attention to the punctuation and the structure (word, phrase or sentence).

1. They can also learn about news from the social media such as _____.
2. In my native country, older people prefer TV news programs, such as _____.
3. However, most young people receive news from the social media; for instance, _____.
4. For me, besides the social media, I also get news from people around me including _____.
5. Some news websites like _____ are very popular among the older people.

4. Exercise 9. Read "The Beginning of Citizen Science" in the lesson material. It has one fragment, one run-on and one comma splice (not including the example). Find and correct them.

More items: lesson material, the Pretest and Exercises 2, 3, 4, 6, 8 and 10. Your tutor can check them.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten sentences about citizen science, some correct and some with a fragment, run-on or comma splice. I will find and fix the errors."
- "Check my answers to Exercises 4 and 6 in the lesson material: [paste]."
- "Here is a paragraph from my psychology notes: [paste]. Mark the three types of errors, but let me correct them."
- "Ask me five questions about how I get the news. I will answer with 'for example', 'such as' or 'including'. Check my punctuation."

Writing task

Exercise 11. Choose one topic from 1-3 and one from 4-6 in the lesson material, and write a paragraph on each (about 8 to 10 sentences). Topics 1-3 are about citizen science (its benefits, its disadvantages, your experience); topics 4-6 are about citizen journalism and other ways ordinary people can help their communities. Watch online has a talk for topic 1 and the report for topic 4.

In each paragraph, use "for example", "for instance", "such as", "like" or "including" at least two times in total.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every sentence has a subject and a verb and expresses a complete idea.
- No dependent clause (because, when, if ...) stands alone after a period.
- No two complete sentences are joined with nothing or with only a comma.
- "For example" and "for instance" have a comma after them; "such as", "like" and "including" are followed by words or phrases.

- A capital letter starts every new sentence.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- "Citizen Science: Everyone Counts", a TEDx talk by Caren Cooper (topic 1): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G7cQHSqfSzI
- "Citizen Journalism Provided Glimpses of Mumbai Attacks", a New York Times report (topic 4; it may need a subscription): https://www.nytimes.com/2008/11/30/world/asia/30twitter.html

Answer key

1. Exercise 1 (book): 1 True; 2 True; 3 False; 4 False; 5 True; 6 True; 7 False; 8 False; 9 False; 10 False. (Item 4 describes what citizen scientists do, so it needs a subject: "They observe nature and record the data.")

2. Exercise 5. The book gives no key. Any of the four ways is correct if the punctuation is right; one or two fixes are given.

1. Comma splice. This is a true story. It happened a few years ago.
2. Run-on. …forty-five former classmates. We had attended the same junior high school class many years before.
3. Comma splice. …posted a message. It said that Mr. Wu, one of our teachers, had just passed away.
4. Run-on. We were very sad, so we shared our old memories of that teacher in the chat.
5. Run-on. Two days later, a message popped up. It was from Mr. Wu!
6. Run-on. He seldom spoke, so we forgot that he was in the group. (Or: Because he seldom spoke, we forgot …)
7. Comma splice. …that he was still alive. He even posted his recent photo to prove that. (Or: …still alive, and he even posted …)
8. Run-on. We were relieved, and we started to greet him.
9. Comma splice. The student who had posted the wrong news was embarrassed, but we did not blame him.
10. Run-on. …the importance of checking the facts. We were pleased that the fact was a happy one in our case.

3. Exercise 7. (example answers) 1. …such as Facebook and Instagram. 2. …such as the evening news on the national channel. 3. …for instance, they watch short news videos on their phones. (a complete sentence, with no capital letter after the semicolon) 4. …including my classmates and my parents. 5. Some news websites like BBC News are very popular among the older people.

4. Exercise 9. The book gives no key.

- Fragment: "…only recently. The practice …" → "Even though many people have heard about the term "citizen science" only recently, the practice of community involvement started as early as 1800s." ("as early as the 1800s" is better English.)
- Comma splice: "…one of the first people, he started …" → "…one of the first people. He started a program about bird migration."
- Run-on: "…on cards their efforts …" → "They recorded the information on cards, and their efforts helped advance scientific research and understanding of birds." (Or: "…on cards. Their efforts …")

My notes